

# *The* Bridal Posing Guide.

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*Posing is a skill.*

Here is how to look intentional, natural, and completely yourself.

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- The fundamentals that change everything.
- Standing poses — silhouette, angle, and your gown.
- Walking, movement, and veil work.
- What to do with your hands — and your bouquet.
- Expressions, eyes & authentic moments.
- How to prepare — your session, your way.

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NYDAM PHOTOGRAPHY

*“Genuine. Intentional. Timeless.”*

nydamphoto.com · Austin, Texas · Est. 2008

WELCOME

# Posing Is a Skill.

Not a performance.

Not something you either have or don't.

*"The stiffness you feel in front of a camera? Completely normal.*

*Not a you problem. A practice problem."*

NYDAM PHOTOGRAPHY

Every bride who walks into a bridal session feeling uncertain walks out with images she loves. The awkwardness doesn't last — it never does. This guide exists to shorten the warm-up and get you to the beautiful part faster.

Posing is our job, not yours. We direct everything — where to stand, where to look, what to do with your hands. You will never be left guessing or told to just 'look natural.' We create the conditions for natural. You just show up.

But understanding a few fundamentals before your session means you warm up faster, feel more at ease, and already know your best angles before we begin. Read this once. Practice in a mirror. Then arrive ready to be in the moment.

WHAT'S INSIDE

- 01 The Fundamentals →
- 02 Standing Poses →
- 03 Walking & Movement →
- 04 What to Do With Your Hands →
- 05 Expressions & Eyes →
- 06 Your Bridal Session — What to Expect →

01

# The Fundamentals.

These principles apply to every pose in this guide. Master them and everything else becomes effortless. Each one is worth practicing in a mirror before your session.

## + The chin trick. Practice this first.

Push your chin slightly forward and down — not up, not back. This defines your jawline, creates a longer neck, and eliminates shadows. It feels unnatural. It photographs beautifully. Practice until it's automatic.

## + Shift your weight — always.

Equal weight on both feet reads as rigid. Shift 70% of your weight to one leg and let the opposite hip drop naturally. Instantly you have shape, angle, and ease. This is the single highest-impact thing you can do in any standing pose.

## + Turn your shoulders — find your angle.

Facing straight-on is rarely your strongest look. Turn your shoulders 30–45 degrees away from the camera while keeping your face toward it. This creates dimension and a more refined silhouette. We'll find your better side in the first five minutes.

## + Relax your shoulders — actively.

Tension goes to your shoulders first. Before every shot, take a breath and consciously drop them down and back. This one reset changes your posture, your expression, and the entire energy of the image.

## + Lean slightly forward — in the right moments.

A subtle forward lean from the waist creates confident, engaged posture. It feels strange. It looks polished and present. We'll cue you exactly when to use it.

## + Breathe. Right before the shutter.

Take a breath and let half of it out just before we shoot. Your shoulders drop, your expression softens, and you go from 'posing' to being present. We'll cue this — but knowing it helps.

## + Poses are starting points, not destinations.

The best bridal images almost always happen between poses — when you're adjusting, laughing, looking away and back. Don't try to hold anything perfectly. Move within it. We catch the in-between.

## + Trust the first ten minutes.

Every single bride feels uncertain at the start. Every single one relaxes within minutes. We know this rhythm. We build sessions around it. Your only job is to be present.

02

# Standing Poses.

Standing poses show your full gown and silhouette — they're often the most editorial images of a bridal session. The key is always weight shift, angle, and giving your hands a purpose.

## 1 Weight Shift & Turn

Shift weight to your back leg, cross front ankle slightly in front. Turn shoulders 45° from the camera, face toward it. Bouquet hand relaxed at hip height, other hand at side or touching the gown. Classic. Endlessly flattering in any dress silhouette.

## 2 The Lean

One shoulder resting lightly against a wall, column, or doorframe. Hip pops naturally outward. Bouquet held loosely in front. Head tilted slightly toward the surface. Creates a relaxed, editorial quality that works in every venue.

## 3 Gown in Hand

Gather a section of your skirt lightly in one hand — at the side or in front. The gesture creates movement, fills the frame, and gives your hand a clear purpose. Especially beautiful with full skirts and ballgowns mid-walk.

## 4 The Profile Turn

Turn your body almost fully sideways to the camera, chin turned back toward the lens. Shows the back of the gown, the train, and the full silhouette. One of the most architecturally beautiful angles in bridal photography.

## 5 Step Forward

One foot takes a small step toward the camera. Weight shifts forward, shoulders back, chin forward and down. Creates movement and dynamic energy in a still pose. Works especially well for venue grand entrances.

## 6 Against Architecture

Back lightly against a wall, column, or arch. Arms relaxed. Bouquet held at hip or mid-body. Face turned toward the light source. Use the venue's architecture — every venue has a natural frame built into it.

### STANDING TIPS THAT MAKE EVERY POSE WORK BETTER

#### + Feet: never parallel, never equal.

One foot always slightly in front of or behind the other.

Equal-weight parallel feet is the fastest way to look rigid in a still pose.

#### + Bouquet at hip height, not chest height.

Holding the bouquet at your chest blocks the bodice of the gown. At hip height it frames the dress and keeps the neckline and face visible.

#### + Train and hem awareness.

Be conscious of where the train is pooling and where the hem sits. A slight kick back of the foot to spread the train reads as effortless on camera.

#### + Look for something to interact with.

A column, an arch, a window. Poses with a physical anchor always look more intentional than floating in open space.

03

# Walking & Movement.

Movement breaks stiffness instantly. Some of the most editorial bridal images come from a bride in motion — walking, turning, letting the dress move. You don't have to be graceful. We time the camera to your best moment.

## MOVEMENT POSES

- + **Walk toward the camera.**  
Start 20 feet away and walk naturally toward us. Eyes can meet the camera, look down, or track slightly off to the side. This prompt alone produces more usable editorial images than almost anything else.
- + **Walk away and look back.**  
Walk away from the camera, then turn to look back over one shoulder. The twist creates a beautiful diagonal line through the frame. Especially stunning with a cathedral train or veil movement.
- + **Let the dress lead.**  
Walk at a slight angle to the camera so the gown fans out naturally. A subtle kick of the foot on each step catches the skirt and creates movement that no amount of still posing can replicate.
- + **Veil toss.**  
Reach both hands back, lift the veil overhead, and let it fall. You don't need wind. You don't need to be graceful. The camera catches the second the veil is fully extended above you.
- + **Bouquet in motion.**  
Let the bouquet swing naturally as you walk rather than holding it rigid. Movement in the bouquet adds life and informality to what would otherwise be a composed, structured image.

## IN-BETWEEN MOMENTS

- + **Adjusting the gown or train.**  
Smoothing the skirt, spreading the train, tucking a strap. These small self-adjusting gestures photograph as completely natural and candid. Some of the most editorial images come from these non-poses.
- + **Looking down, then up on cue.**  
Eyes down. On our cue, slowly lift your gaze to the camera. The moment your eyes come up is almost always where the most genuine expression lives. We use this often.
- + **The pause mid-walk.**  
Stop mid-step, weight forward, looking off to one side. The body is still in motion energy but frozen. It reads as completely unstaged and completely intentional at once.
- + **Laughing — at nothing in particular.**  
We'll say something or create a moment. Real laughter is always better than a posed smile. The session should feel like a good morning, not a photoshoot. These images reflect that.
- + **Between poses — we're still shooting.**  
The few seconds while you're shaking out your hands, adjusting, resetting — the camera is running. Some of the most genuine images come from exactly those unguarded in-between moments.

## THE TRUTH ABOUT MOVEMENT

*Don't perform the movement. Just do it. Walking like you're actually walking always looks better than walking for the camera.*

04

# What to Do With Your Hands.

Hands are where brides freeze most. They're in the frame more than you'd expect — especially in close-up and three-quarter shots. The solution is always the same: give them a purpose.

## Bouquet at hip height.

Hold it at hip height, not chest level. Hip height frames the gown, keeps the bodice visible, and prevents the bouquet from blocking your neckline. Hands relaxed, not gripped.

## Touch the veil lightly.

One hand reaches up to lightly hold the veil or bring it forward over a shoulder. Creates graceful height and draws the eye upward toward your face.

## Touch your gown.

Gather a section of the skirt lightly. A gentle hold at the hip, a slight lift of the hem, or fingers resting on the fabric. Always intentional, never forced.

## Lightly at the collarbone.

One hand resting at the collarbone or touching jewelry. Draws the eye up, adds elegance, and works beautifully in close-up portraits.

## Arms at sides — with intention.

If arms are at your sides, keep fingers slightly curved — not stiff, not fully open. A loose natural curl is almost invisible on camera. Rigid fingers read as tense.

## Hold something meaningful.

Your bouquet, a family heirloom, a letter from the groom. Props give your hands clear purpose and add a layer of story to the image.

## Touch your hair.

Run fingers lightly through hair, tuck a strand, or hold a section near the face. Creates movement and draws attention to your expression.

## Both hands in the gown.

Both hands gathering the skirt slightly at the front or sides. Especially beautiful mid-walk. Full commitment works better than tentative touching.

## One arm across the body.

One arm crosses lightly at the waist, hand resting on the opposite forearm. Creates shape, fills the space between arm and body without looking forced.

## THE ONE RULE

*Never let your hands just hang. Always give them a reason to be exactly where they are.*

05

# Expressions & Eyes.

Expression is the difference between a portrait and a photograph. Your eyes communicate more than any pose ever could. Here's how to think about expression — and how to get there naturally.

## EXPRESSION TYPES

- + **The genuine smile — not the camera smile.**  
Think of something actually funny, or listen to a song that moves you. The goal is never 'smile for the camera' — it's creating a moment worth smiling at. We'll make it happen.
- + **The soft smile — confident and warm.**  
Slightly upturned lips, relaxed jaw, eyes softly narrowed. Not a full smile, not neutral. Communicates quiet confidence. This is often the expression in the framed print that stops people.
- + **Neutral and editorial.**  
No smile. Eyes forward or slightly off camera. Chin forward and down. This reads as intentional and cinematic. Many brides feel like they look serious. They don't. They look like the cover of a magazine.
- + **The real laugh.**  
We'll earn this. When it comes — and it always does — it produces the most authentic images of the entire session. Your only job is not to suppress it.

## WHERE TO LOOK

- + **Directly at the camera.**  
The most powerful connection. Eyes that look into the lens look directly at whoever views the image — for the rest of their life. We use this for the images that get framed.
- + **Just past the camera.**  
Looking slightly past the lens at something just over our shoulder. Creates a thoughtful, softly contemplative quality without losing presence. Beautiful for editorial variety within a single look.
- + **Down, then up on cue.**  
Eyes down, then slowly lifted to the camera. The moment your gaze comes up is almost always where the most genuine expression lives. We use this often.
- + **Off to one side — candid and editorial.**  
Looking completely to one side or into the distance. Gives the image a cinematic, story-in-progress quality. Works beautifully in motion shots and adds variety across the session.

## THE SQUINCH — THE ONE EXPRESSION TRICK WORTH KNOWING

Squint very slightly — just the lower eyelid lifting a touch. Not a full squint. Not wide open. This slight narrowing reads as confidence and warmth. Wide-open eyes in every shot read as surprised. A slight squinch reads as present and engaged. Practice in a mirror. It's subtle. It makes a real difference.

06

# Your Session, Your Way.

This is how a Nydam Photography bridal session actually flows — so nothing is a surprise when you arrive. Knowing the rhythm in advance means you can relax into it instead of wondering what comes next.

## THE FIRST 10–15 MINUTES

This is the warmup — and it is fully intentional. We ease in with movement: adjusting the gown, walking through the space, getting comfortable with the environment and the light. No formal poses yet. No pressure to perform. The camera is running. We are capturing. But the direction hasn't started. By the time it does, you've already forgotten to feel stiff.

## THE GUIDED EXPERIENCE

Every pose, every angle, every expression is directed with intention. You will always know where to stand, where to look, what to do with your hands — because we will be right there guiding you through it. We work together. If something doesn't feel right, say so. We'd rather find what's true to you than have you hold anything that doesn't feel genuine.

## GOWN AND VEIL WORK

We plan time specifically for gown detail shots: the train spread full, close-ups of the bodice, veil movement, rings, florals. This is where we slow down deliberately. These images are often the ones that become wall pieces. They require intention, not speed.

## THE SECOND HALF

This is where the best images of the session almost always happen. You are warmed up, relaxed, and no longer thinking about what your face is doing. The session stops feeling like a session and starts feeling like a beautiful morning. We are still working. It just doesn't feel like it anymore.

*“We come prepared — every session planned with intention.  
And then we create something real — something that stops you in your tracks  
ten years from now.”*



## About Nydam Photography.

We have been photographing Austin families, seniors, couples, and milestones since 2008. Every session we do is personal. We arrive prepared — every session planned with intention — and we create something real.

We photograph with natural light and flash — almost always, even outdoors — because the quality of the image matters more than the convenience of the approach. Every image is considered. Every detail is intentional.

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### GENUINE

Every portrait should feel like you — not a polished version of someone else. We create the conditions for real moments, then capture them.

### INTENTIONAL

Light, posing, expression, timing — every element of a great portrait is considered in advance and guided with care throughout.

### TIMELESS

We edit for longevity, not for trends. The images we create together are meant to stop you in your tracks ten years from now.

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Weddings · Families & Portraits · Seniors · Sacraments · Quinceañeras · Events · Sports · Corporate Headshots & Branding

*Every specialty. One standard of care.*

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### KNOW SOMEONE WHO DESERVES THIS?

Pass this guide along — or send them directly to us. The right photographer changes everything. If you found yours — share that gift. A referral from a client is the highest compliment we receive.

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*With warmth,*

**Arlen and Tanya Nydam, Nydam Photography**

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